



Robots to the rescue

From supply convoys to drone deliveries, robots have proven to be very useful during the pandemic. <https://digit.in/jun20-126>



Post pandemic trends

Some companies got a legup during the pandemic, but which of these will continue to grow? <https://digit.in/jun20-127>

implementation and marketing. MSN TV was like a crippled browser, running off a thin client, with a TV for a display. Since there were no “apps” back then, and TVs were meant to be watched with feet up, and no inputs required, the product was a huge flop. Still, it was a precursor for smart TVs everywhere.

DYNABOOK

This is not a real product. It was a vision of Alan Kay, a famous American Computer Scientist, best known for his work on the GUI, and his support of the One Laptop Per Child project that was started by Nicholas Negroponte. In fact, Negroponte is Kay's friend, and started the OLPC project with the Dynabook in mind. So what is the Dynabook? It's a concept device similar to a laptop, tablet or slate device, and Kay wanted to build it specifically with children in mind.

While Kay wanted to build the device for children, and wanted it to have a near eternal battery life, this is rumoured to have sparked interest from the US military, who also wanted a device that would be flat (easy to pack into a soldier's backpack), and capable



Alan Kay with a mockup of a Dynabook in 2008

of storing thousands of paper manual for field repairs or instructions for operations, etc. Since no Dynabook has ever been built with Kay's original specifications, this is not a flop, but rather a product still waiting to be made. Kay has often criticised the iPad and Steve Jobs for being more focused on commercial aspects rather than actually designing something with children in mind. He's been critical of

Microsoft's Surface as well, but called it “the first Dynabook-like computer good enough to criticize.”

NES POWER GLOVE

If you've been following the hype around Half Life: Alyx, you know that Alyx wears a glove that enables her to control things. A company called AGE (Abrams/Gentile Entertainment) agreed, but 31 years ago! Age built a glove for the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) that



The Power Glove wasn't very good, but it was a good idea

was all the rage back in 1989. The attempt was to try and bring VR-like control to the NES, and hopefully introduce a new way to access in-game controls, hopefully ways that were more realistic and immersive. It flopped, and was discontinued just a year after its 1989 launch!

The glove had 9 buttons that were programmable, so you could use it with a game not built for the glove, and set actions for various glove movements, such as folding the fingers or turning the glove over. There were two games released in the US – Super Glove Ball and Bad Street Brawler – that had special moves that could only be accomplished with the Power Glove. VR gamers today will instantly recognise what AGE was trying to do, 31 long years ago!

QUBE

Jumping back to 1977 again, we come across the first experimental multi-programme cable television network system, which paved the way for interactive TV that would be a big hit later on. Of course cable TV is dying out now, but at one point, it ruled over our lives all across the world!

QUBE started out as a cable box that enabled local, national and, at the time, a new concept of pay-per-view channels. At the time, Warner Bros had a small cable TV division, and releasing QUBE saw them eventually peak at about 200,000 paying households. This certainly cannot be called a flop, because 1 in 10 households had the QUBE box in their houses! The problem was that in their quest for interactive services and offerings, Warner took it too far, and they didn't keep an eye on their finances either. From their launch in 1977 until 1982 they racked up \$99 million in debt, and tying up with shows, paying royalties and the like to try and get better content, their debt skyrocketed to a whopping \$875 million, just one year later (1983). It wasn't just the debt though, because once news got out that Warner was storing data from the interactive sessions of their users, it started the QUBE's demise – data such as what shows families liked, what political candidate they preferred... thanks to interactive questions asked during political debates, for example... no matter how hard Warner tried to convince subscribers that their data was safe, they were not believed. The idea of hackers was spreading to the common man, who knew nothing was really private if it was in the hands of a company, and of course, looking at the skyrocketing debt, which newspapers were happy to scream about, subscribers weren't too convinced that Warner wouldn't sell politicians access to their data. Thus died the QUBE, with the last models being phased out in 1984.

The QUBE was essentially how we use interactive satellite TV now, or on-demand services such as Hotstar, Netflix, Prime Video, YouTube, etc. Except now we know that the companies use our own data against us to market stuff they want us to buy.

GOPHER

A precursor to the world wide web, and eventual loser to hypertext transfer protocol (HTTP), Gopher was the first attempt at building the world